Wilderness and Conquest

Numbers 13–14; Deuteronomy 6–8; Joshua 1–6

The big idea: An eleven-day walk took Israel forty years because they would not trust God at the border. God carried them anyway, kept every promise, and brought a new generation in under Joshua. Jesus, the better Joshua, passed every wilderness test and leads his people into God's rest.

Before you meet: Read

Numbers 13:25–14:24 | Numbers 21:4–9 | Deuteronomy 6:4–9; 8:2–5 | Joshua 1:1–9; 2:8–21 | Matthew 4:1–11

Open (5 minutes)

Think of a time fear kept you from doing something you knew was right. What were you afraid of?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"It is eleven _____ journey from Horeb by the way of Mount Seir to Kadesh-barnea." *(Deuteronomy 1:2)*

"If the LORD _____ in us, he will bring us into this land and give it to us." *(Numbers 14:8)*

"And if a serpent bit anyone, he would _____ at the bronze serpent and _____." *(Numbers 21:9)*

"Man does not live by _____ alone, but man lives by every _____ that comes from the mouth of the LORD." *(Deuteronomy 8:3)*

"By faith _____ the prostitute did not perish with those who were disobedient." *(Hebrews 11:31)*

"Not one _____ of all the good promises that the LORD had made to the house of Israel had failed; all came to pass." *(Joshua 21:45)*

Discuss

1. Caleb and Joshua saw the same giants as the other ten spies. What made the difference? *Numbers 13:30; 14:6–9*

2. God forgave Israel but still let them face forty years of consequences. How do forgiveness and consequences fit together in your own life? *Numbers 14:20–24*

3. Jesus said the bronze serpent was a picture of him. What does it teach about what it means to believe? *John 3:14–15*

4. Deuteronomy says God chose Israel because he loved them, and not because they were better or bigger. Why does that matter for how you see yourself? *Deuteronomy 7:7–8; 9:6*

5. Rahab was a Canaanite and a prostitute, and she became an ancestor of Jesus. What does her story say to someone who thinks they are too far gone? *Joshua 2:8–14; Matthew 1:5*

6. Jesus answered every temptation with words from Deuteronomy. Which verse do you need ready for your own wilderness right now? *Matthew 4:1–11*

Apply this week

Name the fear that is keeping you at the border right now. Write it on a card, and under it write Numbers 14:8–9. Then, like the twelve stones at the Jordan, tell one person this week one specific thing God has done for you.

Memory verse

"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

Joshua 1:9

Pray

Confess the fears that make you want to go back to Egypt. Thank God for the ways he has carried you, like a father carries his son. Ask him for Caleb's different spirit, and thank Jesus for passing every test in your place.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 12

Wilderness and Conquest

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Numbers 13:25–14:9 aloud together. Then read Joshua 2:8–14.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 1, 3, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the timeline and the Tested in the Wilderness chart in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 13 (Judges 2:6–23 and the book of Ruth).

Main points to land

1. Unbelief, not giants, kept Israel out of the land. The ten spies saw the fruit and still would not trust God (Numbers 14:11; Hebrews 3:19).
2. In the wilderness God disciplined his people as a Father and carried them the whole way: manna, water, clothing that did not wear out (Deuteronomy 8:2–5; 1:31).
3. The bronze serpent shows what faith is: a look of trust at the One God has lifted up (Numbers 21:9; John 3:14–15).
4. God chose Israel and gave them the land by grace, not for their righteousness, and he kept every promise (Deuteronomy 7:7–8; 9:6; Joshua 21:45).
5. Jesus is the better Joshua. He passed the tests Israel failed, answering from Deuteronomy, and he leads his people into God's rest (Matthew 4:1–11; Hebrews 4:8–9).

Answer key (Observe)

1. days'
2. delights
3. look; live
4. bread; word
5. Rahab
6. word

Questions people will ask

How could God command Israel to destroy the Canaanites?
Let the question be hard. Read the lesson's section together. God waited centuries before judging nations that burned their children to their gods (Genesis 15:16; Deuteronomy 12:31). Mercy was open, as Rahab and the Gibeonites show. It was a one-time command for one land, never given to the church (John 18:36), and it previews the final judgment, when the only refuge is the mercy God provides in Christ.

Why was Moses kept out of the land for one mistake?

God said Moses did not trust him or honor him as holy before the people (Numbers 20:12). Leaders are held to a high standard. But God still let Moses see the land, buried him himself, and later brought him into the land to speak with Jesus at the transfiguration (Matthew 17:3). His exclusion from Canaan was discipline. It was never a loss of salvation.

Did God really part the Jordan and knock down Jericho's walls?

The Bible presents these as real events, and Hebrews 11:30 treats Jericho's fall as history. Christians who believe God raised Jesus from the dead have no reason to doubt that he can stop a river. Keep the group on the point the text makes: God fought for his people, and they took the land by faith.

Is the Promised Land still Israel's today? What does it mean for Christians?

Faithful Christians disagree about the place of the modern state of Israel in God's plans. The New Testament points the land promise forward: Abraham was promised the world (Romans 4:13), and believers look for a better country (Hebrews 11:16) and a Sabbath rest that remains (Hebrews 4:9). Keep the group on Christ, who gives that rest.

Closing prayer

Father, you carried your people through the wilderness and kept every promise you made. Forgive us for the fears that make us want to turn back. Give us Caleb's different spirit and Rahab's bold faith. Thank you for Jesus, the better Joshua, who passed every test for us and leads us into your rest. Amen.